Subject

Budget narratives with Claude in 5 steps

Save this before budget submissions close

- [ ] **Set the context**
- [ ] **Draft one narrative per cost centre**
- [ ] **Challenge the assumptions**
- [ ] **Prepare the questions**
- [ ] **Summarise for the committee**

Owner _____ Date _____

Swipe for the 5 steps

Step 1 of 5

1

Set the context

Share last year's budget narrative, this year's guidelines and the target. Tell it the tone your CFO expects.

Prompt to copy Paste once.

```
You are helping me write budget narratives for
[ORGANISATION TYPE] for [YEAR].

Budget guidelines: [PASTE]
Last year's narrative style: [PASTE EXAMPLE]
Target tone: factual, short, British English.

Use only the figures and notes I give you. Reply
"Ready".
```

Step 2 of 5

2

Draft one narrative per cost centre

Paste the budget versus prior year and the budget holder's notes. Ask for a short narrative: what changes, why, what it depends on.

Prompt to copy Repeat per cost centre.

```
Cost centre: [NAME]
Budget vs prior year: [PASTE TABLE]
Budget holder notes: [PASTE]

Write a narrative of max 120 words: what changes, why, and
what it depends on.
Mark any change without a reason in the notes with [ASK].
```

Step 3 of 5

3

Challenge the assumptions

Ask: "Which assumptions look optimistic compared with the last two years of actuals?"

Prompt to copy Where Claude adds most value.

```
Here are the key assumptions and the last two years of
actuals: [PASTE]

Which assumptions look optimistic or inconsistent with
the actuals?
For each, explain why in one sentence and suggest the
question to ask.
```

Step 4 of 5

4

Prepare the questions

Ask for three questions per budget holder, focused on the biggest changes.

Prompt to copy Fewer review loops.

```
Based on the submissions, draft three questions for
each budget holder, focused on their largest changes
versus last year.
```

Step 5 of 5

5

Summarise for the committee

Once reviewed, ask for a one-page summary: total change, main drivers, key risks, decisions needed.

Prompt to copy Simple sensitivity in words.

```
If the three largest assumptions are each 10% worse,
describe the effect on the total in plain words.
I will calculate the numbers myself. Tell me which
lines move and in which direction.
```

One rule

Before you start

Budget data by cost centre is usually fine in an approved tool. Salaries and named individuals are not. Aggregate personnel costs first.

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